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**CBIQ**

GLOBAL MOBILITY MARKET INSIGHTS

# GLOBAL WORKFORCE DEPLOYMENT REPORT

The 2026 benchmark of how Global Mobility programs are deploying talent, from strategy and structure to technology, vendors and remote work.

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**2026 REPORT** · Global Mobility Executive × CBIQ

# EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

The Global Mobility landscape is undergoing one of its most significant transformations in decades. As organizations navigate geopolitical uncertainty, economic pressures, evolving workforce expectations, skills shortages, and rapid technological advancement, mobility programs are required to deliver more strategic value while operating under increasing cost and resource constraints.

The findings of the 2026 Global Workforce Deployment Survey reveal a profession at an inflection point. While compliance, governance and cost control remain essential foundations of successful mobility programs, organizations are increasingly viewing Global Mobility as a strategic workforce deployment function capable of supporting broader talent and business objectives.

## This year's survey highlights three key trends.

### Global Mobility is becoming more strategic.

Ninety percent (90%) of respondents believe the role of mobility professionals is becoming increasingly strategic and advisory, while 78% report a closer alignment between the Talent and Global Mobility functions. Mobility teams are no longer simply facilitating employee movement. They are becoming active participants in workforce planning, talent development and succession planning.

### Operating in an environment of increasing complexity.

The demand for global talent remains strong, yet mobility leaders face significant challenges including rising costs, complex compliance obligations, geopolitical volatility, and increasing stakeholder and employee expectations. Cost remains a significant barrier to achieving program objectives, followed closely by leadership buy-in, technology limitations and team capability constraints.

### Technology and AI are emerging as key enablers.

More than half of organizations now utilize assignment management technology and AI adoption is beginning to accelerate. However, survey respondents favor a future model that combines human expertise with technology-enabled support rather than replacing human interaction altogether.

The organizations that will be most successful over the coming years will be those that successfully balance strategic workforce deployment, employee experience, governance, technology and cost management.

**Implications for strategy and operations:** Mobility leaders will need to translate this strategic ambition into practical operating model decisions, defining where Mobility should influence workforce planning, what activities should remain in-house, where technology or vendors can create scale and how the function will evidence value through data, governance and measurable business outcomes.

# INTRODUCTION

## Global Mobility 2026 and beyond - **Adapting to Disruption and Doing More with Less**

Global Mobility has always had to evolve in response to changing business needs. However, the pace of change facing mobility leaders today is unprecedented.

In recent years organizations have experienced significant disruption driven by global pandemics, geopolitical instability, inflationary pressures, talent shortages and the rapid adoption of remote and hybrid working models. These developments have fundamentally changed how organizations think about work, talent and workforce deployment.

At the same time, employee expectations have evolved. Employees increasingly expect flexibility, personalized mobility support and career development opportunities that extend beyond the traditional international assignment. Organizations are responding by exploring a wider range of deployment options, including international remote work, short-term assignments, permanent transfers, self-initiated moves and other alternative employment models.

This shift is expanding the scope of Global Mobility teams beyond their traditional focus on relocation management. Today's mobility leaders are expected to balance multiple priorities simultaneously. They must support business growth, ensure compliance, manage costs, improve employee experience, enable workforce planning and increasingly provide strategic insights to senior leadership.

The findings from this survey indicate that many organizations are actively adapting their mobility operating models to meet these demands. New technologies, AI-enabled solutions and vendor relationships are all becoming important tools in helping organizations build more agile and scalable mobility programs.

Against this backdrop, GME conducted the 2026 Global Workforce Deployment Survey to understand how mobility programs are evolving and to identify the trends that are shaping the future of global workforce deployment. This survey report is essential reading for Global Mobility teams seeking to stay ahead of the latest trends and for any organization reviewing or reshaping its mobility program.

We would like to thank everyone that participated in the survey for their responses and feedback in helping GME to create this survey report.



## How this compares with the wider market

“How this compares with the wider market” draws on the CBIQ cross-border workforce benchmark of 800+ Global Mobility leaders, collected on a rolling basis across 2025-26. They are shown for context only; all survey findings in this report are based solely on the 2026 Global Workforce Deployment Survey responses and are directly comparable with the 2025 survey.

# INTRODUCTION

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Global mobility leaders are navigating an era defined by compounding geopolitical uncertainty, including ongoing conflicts and natural disasters, alongside continued economic pressures. At the same time, employee expectations are evolving as many are more reluctant to relocate and increasingly expect flexible working arrangements, while organizations in many parts of the world are placing a sharper focus on attracting and retaining talent.

Governments are also increasing compliance requirements and, in some jurisdictions, introducing more restrictive immigration policies, adding further complexity to mobility. All of this must be managed in a cost-conscious environment, with technology increasingly being leveraged to improve the employee experience, drive operational efficiencies, and provide strategic insight through data and analytics.

Against this backdrop, global mobility is becoming an increasingly important part of talent management and a key enabler of business growth. The role of global mobility leaders is therefore likely to become more challenging, more strategic, and more integral to the success of their organizations.

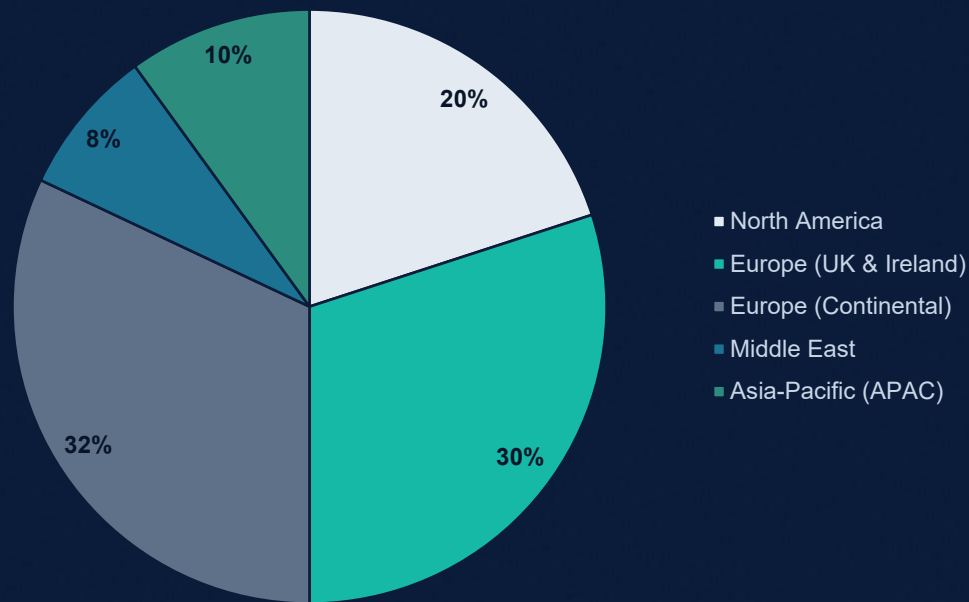
**Julia Onslow-Cole**

GME Advisory Board | Partner - Fragomen



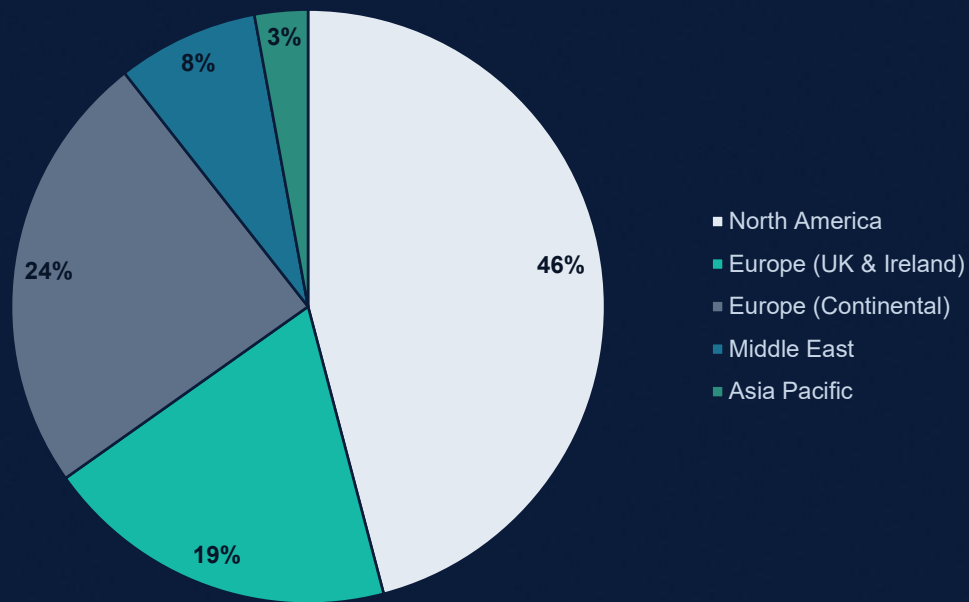
# SURVEY DEMOGRAPHICS

Participants Region Location



The 2026 survey responses provide a strong focus on well established multinational organizations with mature mobility programs. The majority of survey respondents, 62%, are based in Europe, including the UK and mainland Europe, followed by North America at 20%, Asia-Pacific at 10%, and the Middle East at 7.5%. As a result, the findings primarily reflect the priorities, maturity levels and strategic challenges of organizations operating in established global mobility markets.

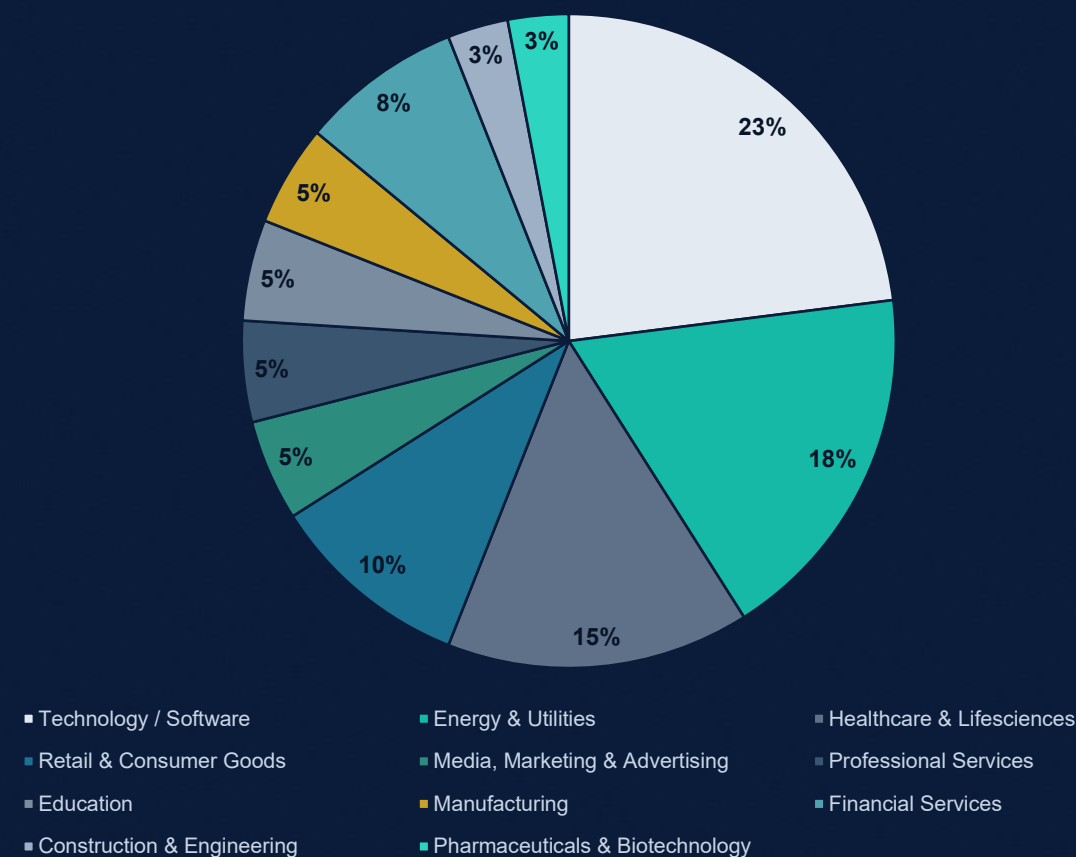
HQ Location of Respondents



Almost half of participants were from North American-headquartered companies, with 25% from Continental Europe and 20% from the UK. The responses provide insights into how mature multinational organizations are positioning mobility within broader workforce, talent and business strategies.

# SURVEY DEMOGRAPHICS

## Industry Sector

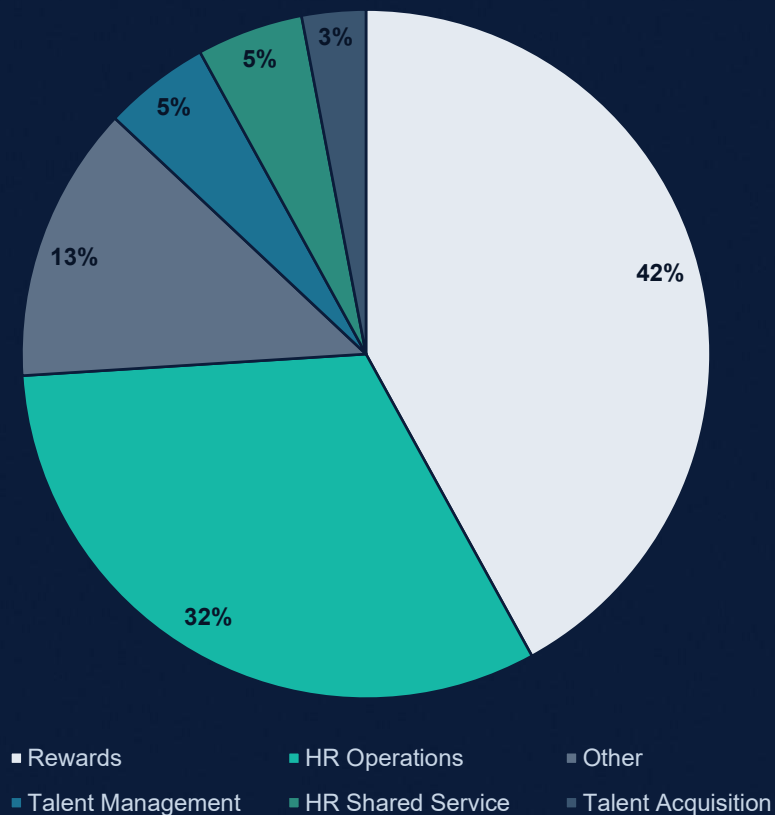


The most represented industry sectors in the survey were Technology (23%), Energy and Utilities (18%), Healthcare (15%), Retail and Consumer Goods (10%), Entertainment & Media (9%), and Manufacturing (5%).

Compared with the 2025 survey, the 2026 respondent base continues to be weighted towards internationally active sectors where workforce deployment, compliance and specialist talent mobility are strategically important. Technology remains the largest represented sector in 2026 at 23%, indicating continued strong participation from organizations managing fast-moving skills, growth and transformation agendas. Energy and Utilities, Healthcare, Retail and Consumer Goods, Entertainment and Media, and Manufacturing also remain important parts of the sample, giving the findings relevance across both knowledge-led and asset-intensive industries. The industry mix should therefore be read as reflecting organizations with relatively mature mobility requirements, rather than the wider employer market as a whole.

# COMPANY STRUCTURE AND SCALE

## Where GM Sits in Organizations

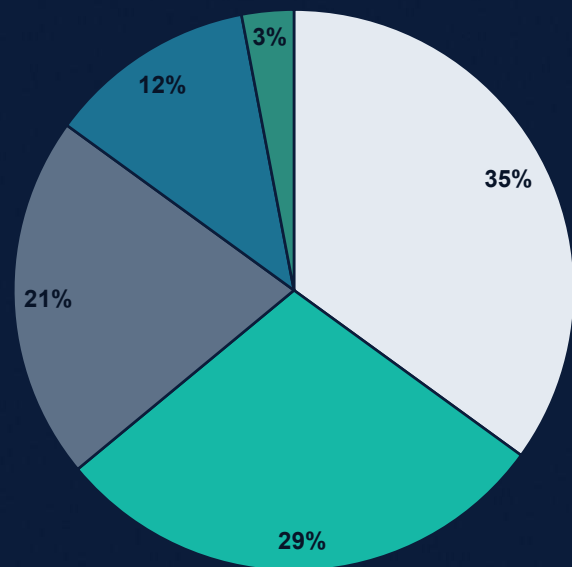


In 2026, the organizational positioning of Global Mobility has changed only slightly from 2025 and remains closely connected to the wider HR agenda. The function most commonly reports into Rewards (42%) or HR Operations (32%), with smaller percentages sitting within HR Shared Services, Talent Management or Talent Acquisition. This structure reinforces the continuing importance of governance, cost management and employee experience, while also highlighting the opportunity for Mobility to play a more active role in strategic workforce planning.

Although there is growing recognition of Global Mobility as a strategic talent lever, its formal organizational home continues to shape how decisions are made. Mobility sits within Rewards or HR Operations and the function is therefore often viewed through the lenses of cost, compliance and process control. The strategic opportunity is to retain these foundations while strengthening Mobility's influence in workforce planning, talent development and business transformation.

# COMPANY STRUCTURE AND SCALE

## How the GM Role is Evolving



- Becoming more strategic and advisory
- Increasing focus on compliance, risk and governance
- Greater emphasis on digital tools and automation
- More integrated with Finance, Legal, HSE etc.
- Staying the same

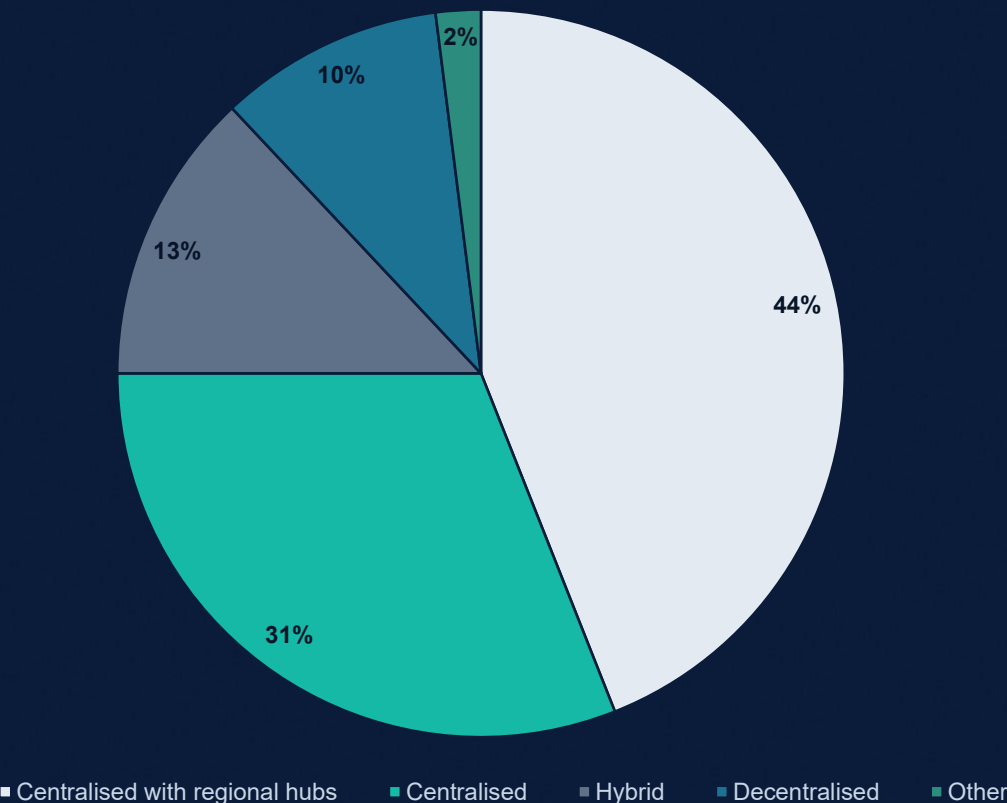
The survey responses suggest that, in the majority of participating organizations, Global Mobility is no longer treated as an operational activity. Instead, it is increasingly recognized as a specialist capability with defined governance, clear ownership and the potential to influence broader workforce deployment decisions.

This is reinforced by the 65% of respondents that stated that Global Mobility is established as a centre of excellence in their organization, indicating a move towards more structured expertise, stronger governance and more consistent strategic advice to the business.



# COMPANY STRUCTURE AND SCALE

## GM Function within the Organizational Structure



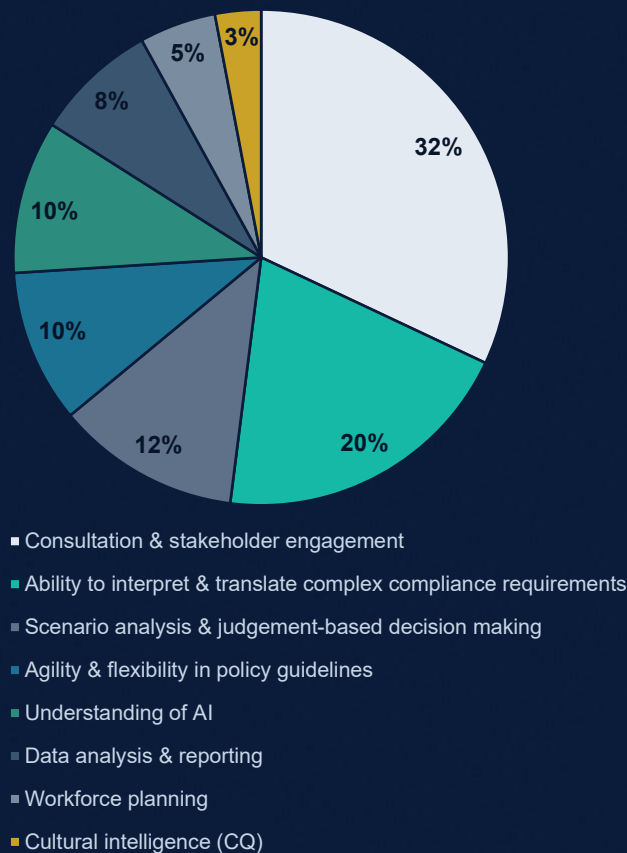
The majority of participants (59%) reported that Global Mobility sits within Rewards, reflecting its continued role in managing cost, equity and compliance. However, as mobility becomes more closely linked to talent strategy, this positioning also creates an opportunity for Rewards, Talent and HR Operations to work more closely together to shape more integrated workforce deployment solutions.

The preferred operating model remains largely centralised, with 44% of organizations favouring a centralised model with regional hubs and 31% favouring a fully centralised model. This points to a desire for global consistency, stronger governance and better strategic control, while still preserving regional insight and responsiveness.

A centre of excellence model can support this strategic shift by creating a single point of expertise, improving decision quality, strengthening governance and enabling more consistent alignment between mobility activity and business priorities.

# COMPANY STRUCTURE AND SCALE

## Emerging GM Skills Needed



Participants were asked about the emerging skills needed by Global Mobility teams. In keeping with the changing role of the function, 33% of companies identified consultative capability and stakeholder management as key skills, while 20% highlighted the ability to interpret complex compliance scenarios. Other important capabilities included scenario analysis, communication and change management, all of which point to a broader shift from administration to strategic advisory work.

Fifty percent of respondents stated that they had not increased Global Mobility resources, while 41% had and 9% were unsure. This indicates that many teams are expected to deliver broader strategic value without any increase in capacity. As AI adoption, alternative deployment models and workforce planning expectations increase, the capability profile of Global Mobility teams is likely to continue evolving.

# ALIGNMENT BETWEEN TALENT AND GLOBAL MOBILITY

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Respondents were asked whether they are seeing closer alignment between Talent and Global Mobility. More than 78% confirmed that this is happening in their organization, representing a slight increase over the 2025 survey. This confirms that Mobility's role is expanding beyond enabling individual moves. Global Mobility leaders are increasingly contributing to workforce planning, succession planning and talent pipeline development.

As Global Mobility Talent leaders, we've spent years building credibility through compliance, governance and operational excellence. What's encouraging in this year's report is the growing recognition that Mobility is now expected to contribute far more directly to workforce planning, talent development and business growth. The challenge ahead is not simply to manage complexity, but to translate mobility activity into measurable business outcomes. Those organizations that successfully combine strategic workforce deployment, data-driven decision making, human expertise and intelligent technology will be best positioned to thrive. Mobility is no longer just about moving talent; it is about enabling organizations to deploy talent where it creates the greatest business impact.

## Vlad Dziak

Head of Global Workforce Deployment and Mobility, Talent Practices and Employee Rewards | Liberty Mutual Insurance

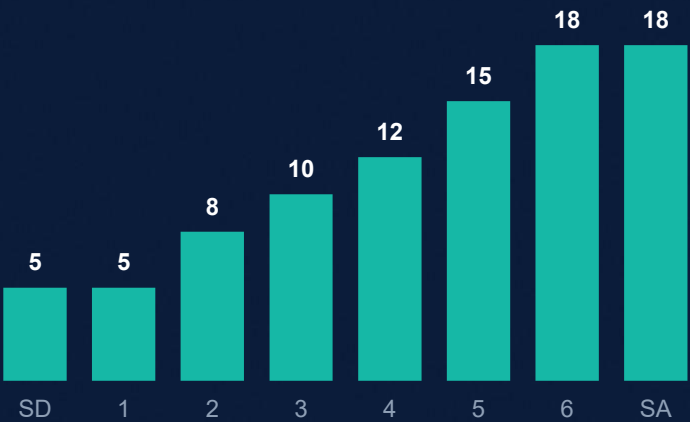
# GLOBAL MOBILITY STRATEGY



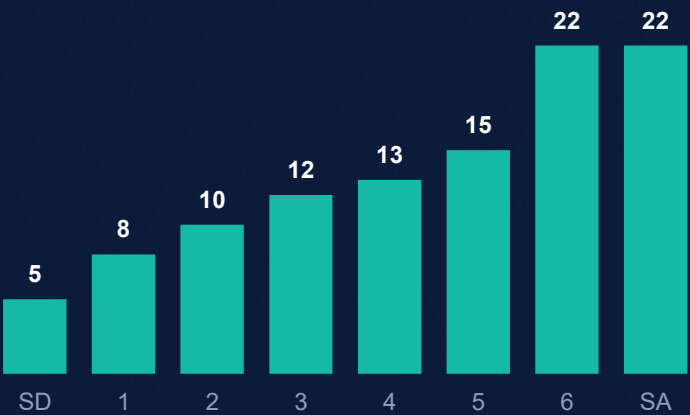
## How this compares with the wider market

The wider market points the same way. In the CBIQ benchmark, 44% of Global Mobility leaders agree strongly that their Global Mobility strategy is well aligned to the broader organizational strategy, and 75% agree overall, directionally consistent with this survey's participants.

We have a Defined Global Mobility Strategy



Our GM Strategy is Well Aligned to Broader Org Strategy



Strongly Disagree ←→ Strongly Agree (0-7 scale)

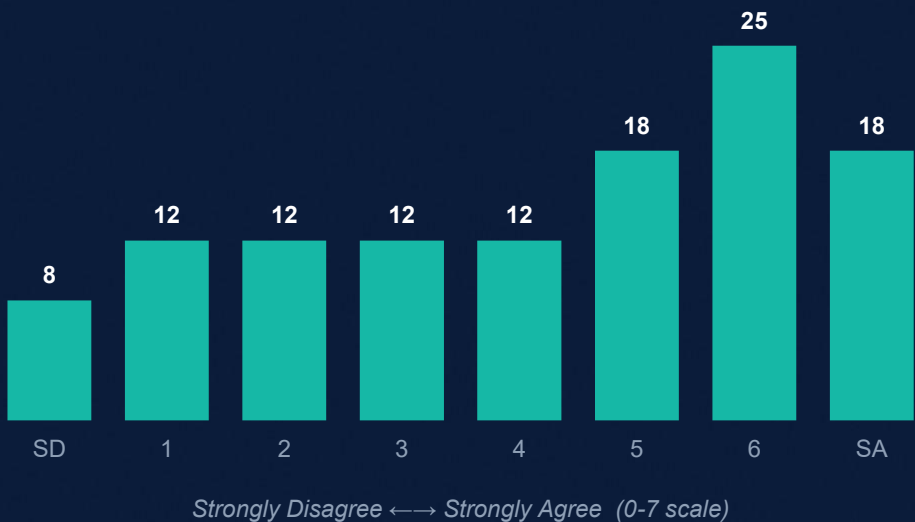
The 2026 results show that most organizations have made progress in defining a Global Mobility strategy, but maturity remains uneven. With both the average and median response sitting at 5 on a 7-point scale, many programs appear to have moved beyond a purely reactive model, but are still building the governance, data and business alignment required to operate as a fully strategic workforce deployment function.

The 2026 responses reinforce the increasing expectation that Global Mobility should align directly with organizational priorities. Compared with the 2025 report, the emphasis on aligning mobility to strategic objectives has strengthened, with the 2026 goals data showing alignment to strategic objectives rising to 62.5%, compared with 52% in 2025.

Base: 655 Global Mobility leaders · CBIQ benchmark · 0-7 agreement scale, strong agreement = 6-7

# GLOBAL MOBILITY STRATEGY

## Global Mobility is Embedded into the Organization's EVP



The 2026 data also suggests that mobility strategy is becoming more closely linked to the employee value proposition. International moves are increasingly viewed not only as business-led deployments, but also as career experiences that can support attraction, retention, leadership development and access to critical skills. This builds on the 2025 survey themes around employee experience and policy enhancement, but the 2026 results indicate a more deliberate attempt to balance employee-centred mobility with stronger governance, cost control and strategic workforce outcomes.



## How this compares with the wider market

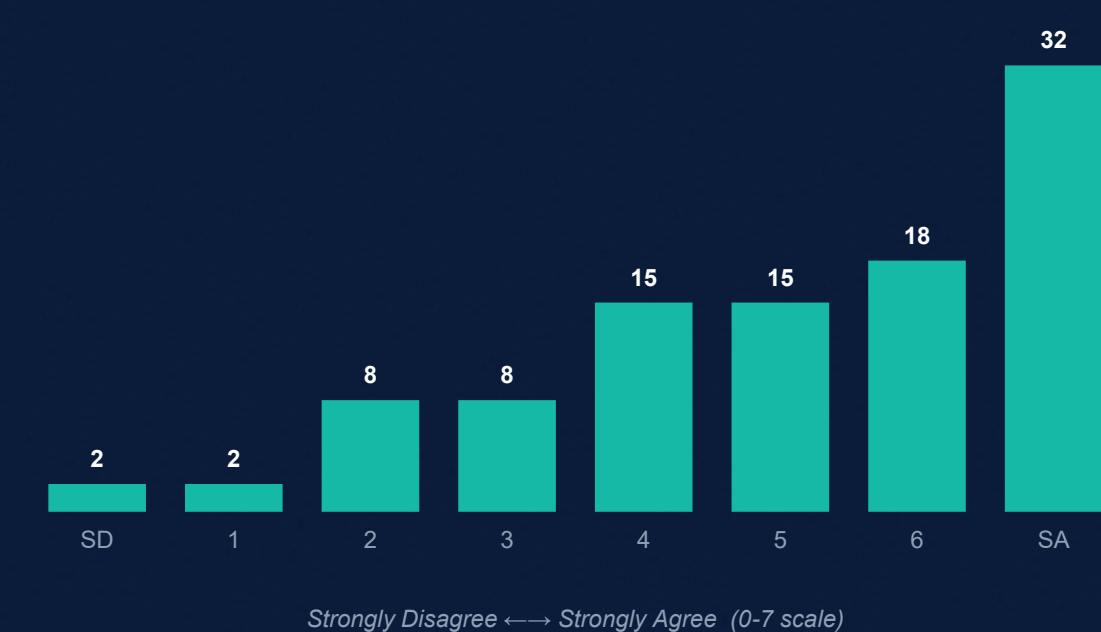
Across the wider market this link is still forming: 39% of leaders agree strongly that Global Mobility is embedded in the organization's employee value proposition (69% agree overall). Ambition on the talent agenda is broadly shared; full embedding remains work in progress.

Base: 642 Global Mobility leaders · CBIQ benchmark · 0-7 agreement scale



# GLOBAL MOBILITY STRATEGY

## The Scope and Complexity of Global Mobility Will Grow in the Next 12 Months



When asked about the complexity and scope of global mobility in the next 12 months, participant’s responses highlight the practical challenge facing many mobility teams: strategic expectations are increasing faster than resources, technology and operating models are evolving.

The comparison with 2025 shows continuity in the core themes of strategic alignment, agility and compliance, but the 2026 results place greater weight on adaptability, cost management and technology. In particular, adaptability increased from 47.5% in 2025 to 60% in 2026, while technology appears more prominently as a strategic goal. This suggests that organizations are now looking for Global Mobility strategies that are not only well defined, but also scalable, data-led and responsive to changing business needs.

# GOALS & BARRIERS TO GM STRATEGY

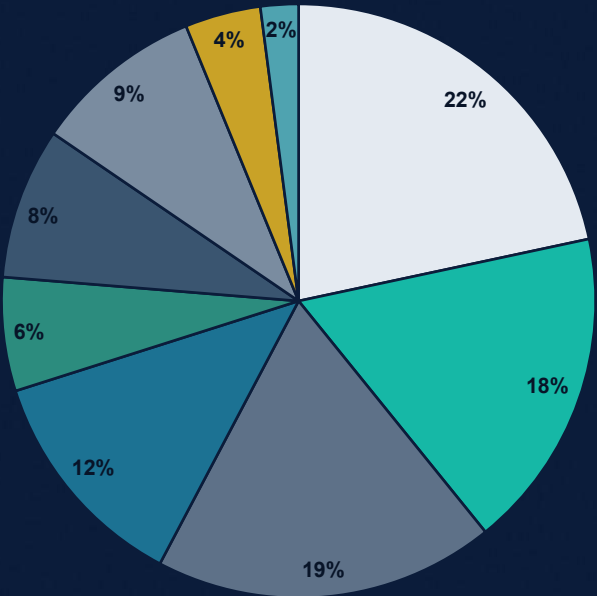


## How this compares with the wider market

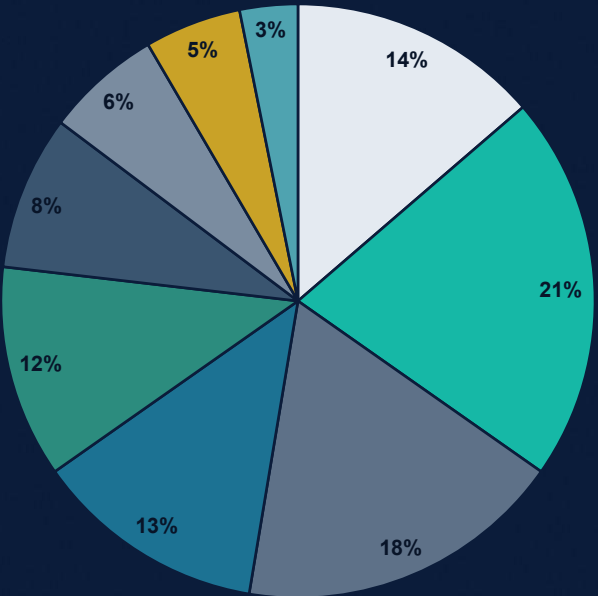
The wider market shares this expectation: 79% of leaders in the CBIQ benchmark agree that the scope and complexity of Global Mobility will grow in the next 12 months, with 49% agreeing strongly. The growth expectation in this survey is not a participant quirk, it is the market view.

Base: 656 Global Mobility leaders · CBIQ benchmark · 0-7 agreement scale

Top Goals 2025



Top Goals 2026



The goals for 2025 and 2026 are broadly consistent, showing that Global Mobility continues to be shaped by the same core priorities: strategic alignment, adaptability, compliance, cost control and employee experience. However, the 2026 data shows a clear strengthening of the strategic and agile workforce agenda. Alignment to strategic objectives increased from 52% in 2025 to 62.5% in 2026, while adaptability rose from 47.5% to 60%.

# GOALS & BARRIERS TO GM STRATEGY

## Top Goals 2025

|                                                |       |
|------------------------------------------------|-------|
| Aligning to strategic objectives               | 52%   |
| Being adaptable to agile business requirements | 47.5% |
| Compliance                                     | 55%   |

## Top Goals 2026

|                                                |       |
|------------------------------------------------|-------|
| Aligning to strategic objectives               | 62.5% |
| Being adaptable to agile business requirements | 60%   |
| Compliance                                     | 47%   |

There are also some important shifts in emphasis. Compliance remains a top priority, but its relative ranking has fallen from 55% in 2025 to 47% in 2026. This does not suggest that compliance has become less important; rather, it indicates that compliance is increasingly viewed as a core foundation of mobility rather than the sole defining objective.

Cost appears as a more important 2026 goal at 45%, reflecting the pressure on Mobility teams to deliver strategic value while managing constrained budgets. Technology also emerges as a major 2026 goal at 45%, highlighting the growing need for better data, workflow automation, reporting and scalable service delivery.



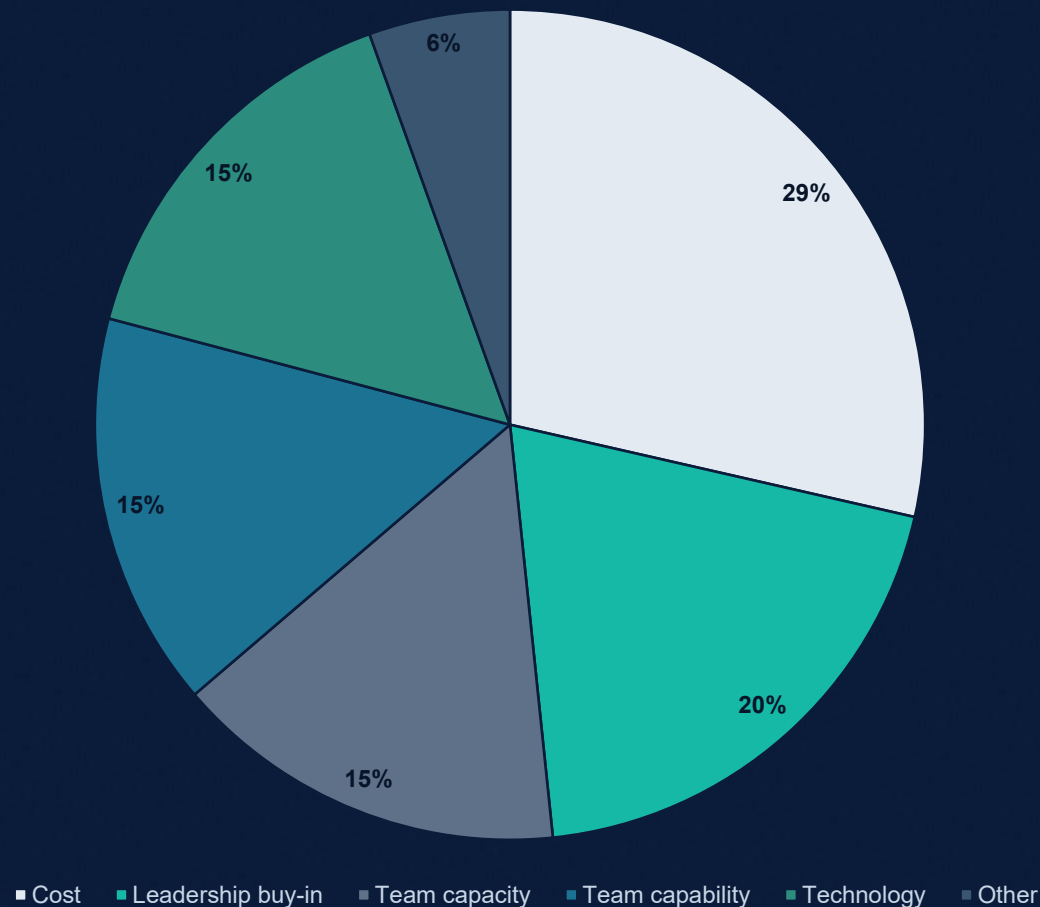
## How this compares with the wider market

The same pressures lead in the wider market. Among the top operational pressures cited by leaders in the CBIQ benchmark, immigration and regulatory change (16%), cost management (15%) and geopolitical instability (15%) form the leading cluster, with remote work compliance close behind (12%). Compliance and cost are market-wide constants, not survey artefacts.

*Base: approximately 810 Global Mobility leaders · CBIQ benchmark · top pressures, multiple answers allowed*

# GOALS & BARRIERS TO GM STRATEGY

Top 3 Barriers to Achieving GM Priorities



## Summary Interpretation

The comparison shows that Global Mobility strategy is moving from a compliance-led and policy-led discipline towards a broader workforce deployment agenda. The 2026 goals point to a function that is expected to be more strategic, more adaptable, more data-enabled and more commercially aware. For operations, this means Mobility teams will need clearer prioritisation frameworks, stronger technology and reporting capability, and closer engagement with Talent, Rewards, HR Operations and business leaders.

Cost, team capacity and technology remain the top barriers to delivering on Global Mobility strategy, but they also highlight where future investment and operating model decisions will have the greatest strategic impact. The addition of new response options in the 2026 Survey, including leadership buy-in and the distinction between capacity and capability, suggests that organizations are beginning to view mobility challenges as strategic questions about influence, investment and organizational readiness.

# STRATEGY SECTION SUMMARY

Overall, the strategy findings show a Global Mobility function that is becoming more strategically important, but still developing the structures, data and influence needed to realise its full potential.

Compared with the 2025 report, the 2026 results show a stronger emphasis on aligning mobility with organizational objectives, increasing adaptability and using technology and policy flexibility to support more responsive workforce deployment.

While compliance remains important, the year-on-year comparison suggests that Mobility leaders are being asked to deliver a broader strategic agenda: enabling business growth, strengthening talent deployment, managing cost and risk, and improving the employee experience. At the same time, cost, capacity, capability and leadership buy-in remain important barriers.

Future success will therefore depend on Mobility teams being able to demonstrate value, connect activity to business and talent outcomes, and build operating models that can scale in a more complex environment.

**Implications for strategy and operations:** Strategically, organizations should treat Global Mobility as part of enterprise workforce planning rather than a downstream service. Operationally, this requires clearer governance, better prioritisation of high-value moves, stronger decision frameworks for flexible deployment models, and more consistent data on cost, risk, employee experience and business impact.



## How this compares with the wider market

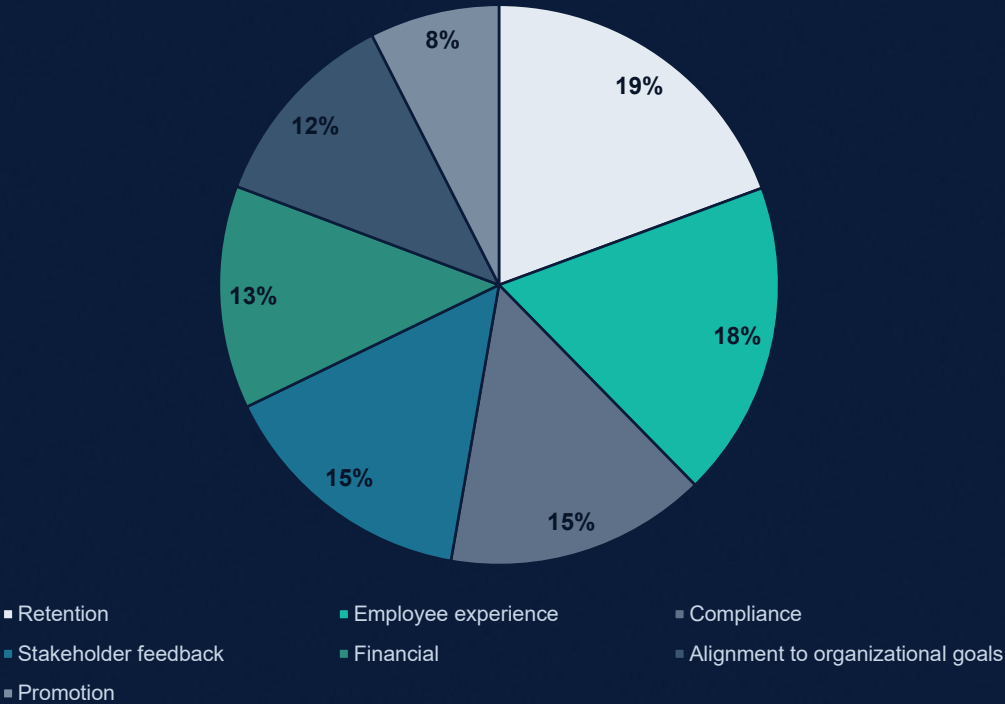
The wider market tells the same transition story. In the CBIQ benchmark, 28% of programs describe themselves as optimising selected areas, 26% as reviewing processes and technology, 24% as operating effectively and 22% as actively transforming, most programs are adjusting, few consider the job finished.

*Base: approximately 780 Global Mobility leaders · CBIQ benchmark*

# ROI

## What ROI measures do you apply?

Respondents were asked whether they measure the return on investment of their Global Mobility program. Forty-five percent stated that they do, while the majority, 55% said they do not. This remains a significant strategic gap: without clearer measures of value, Mobility teams may find it harder to demonstrate their contribution to business growth, talent outcomes and workforce resilience.



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One of the most significant findings in this year's survey is that while Global Mobility is increasingly recognized as a strategic workforce deployment function, more than half of organizations still do not formally measure ROI. As expectations for Mobility continue to expand, establishing meaningful outcome-based measures will be critical to demonstrating value and securing future investment. Organizations that successfully combine mobility analytics, technology and ROI measurement will be best positioned to demonstrate business impact.

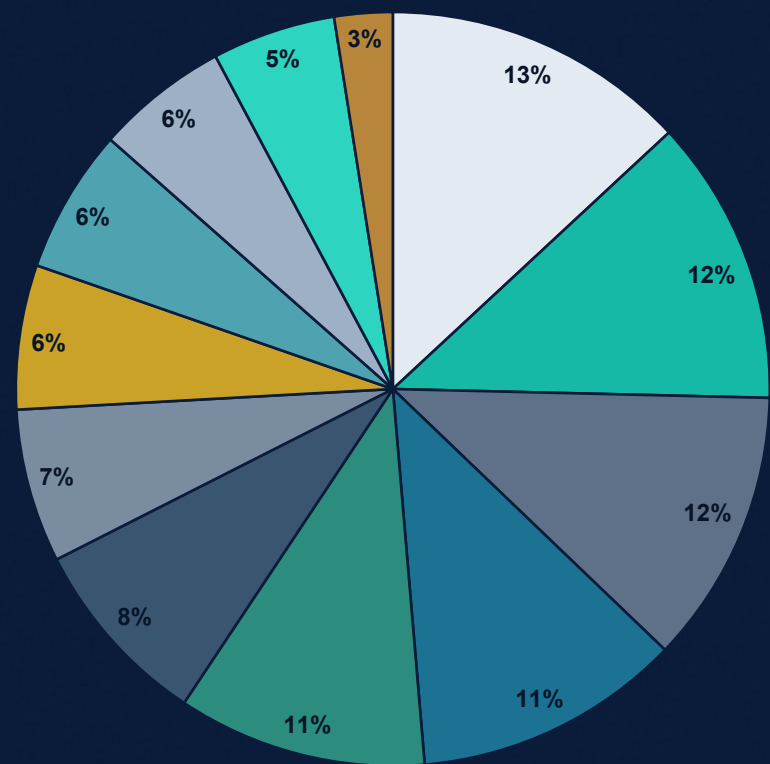
**Pradeep Setlur**

Vice President | International Talent Mobility and Immigration, Cap Gemini



# POLICIES

## Policy Types



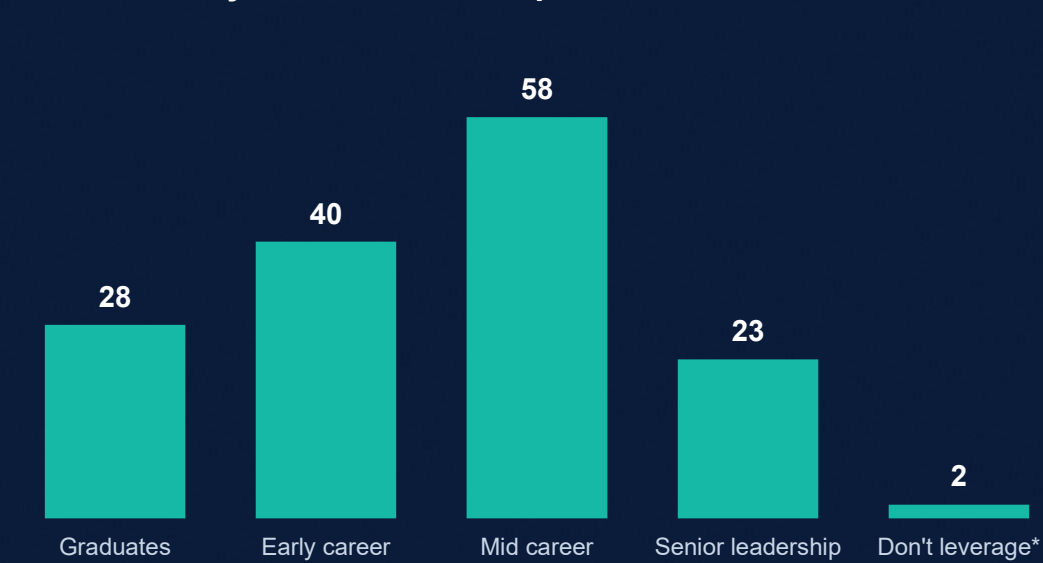
The policy mix shown in the responses suggests that organizations are no longer relying on a single traditional assignment model.

Instead, mobility frameworks are becoming more segmented, with long-term assignments, short-term assignments, permanent transfers, foreign local hires and remote or hybrid work arrangements all forming part of the deployment toolkit.

This reflects a more strategic approach to matching the type of move to the business objective, employee profile, cost tolerance and compliance risk.

# POLICIES

## Use of Mobility for Talent Development



*\*We do not leverage global mobility for talent development programs*

The majority of organizations leverage global mobility as a tool for talent development across all career stages. Long-term assignments and permanent transfers remain important because they are often linked to leadership development, succession planning and market expansion. As in the 2025 survey, senior leadership and early career talent programs were the most popular. Interestingly the number of organizations not using global mobility for developmental purposes has increased to just over 22%.

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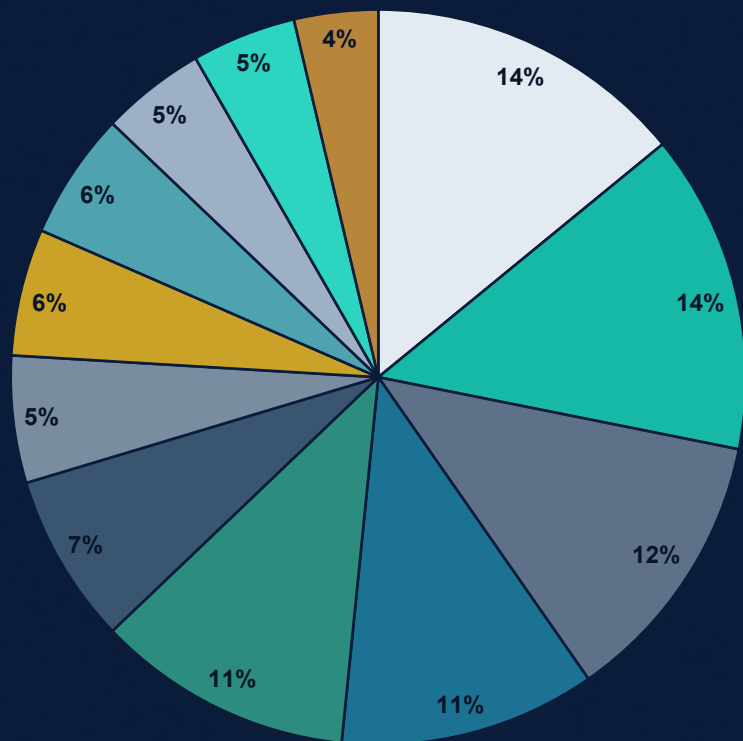
Mobility continues to deliver meaningful benefits for both employees and the business. The findings reinforce the importance of designing mobility programs that are aligned to both organizational priorities and employee needs. Rather than increasing flexibility for its own sake, leading organizations are creating more tailored mobility pathways that support talent deployment, career growth, and business performance while effectively managing risk and cost.

**Michelle Durkin**

Director, Mobility Strategy and Program Lead

# POLICY REVIEW

## Policies Under Review



- International long term assignments
- International short term assignments
- International permanent transfers
- International hires
- Foreign local hires
- International remote work
- Extended business travel
- Business travel
- Commuters
- VIP moves
- Self-initiated moves
- Career development

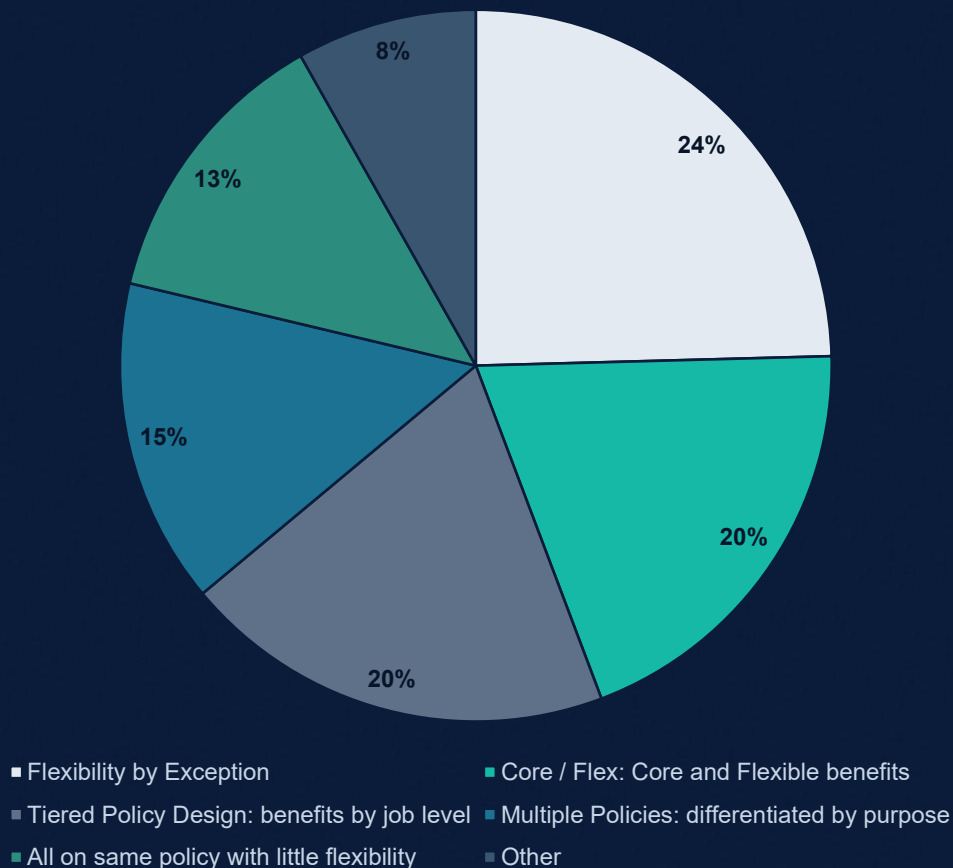
Survey participants were asked if they are reviewing their policies. The majority, 53%, stated that they are, but 33% said they are not and a further 14% are considering a review. Organizations are increasingly using multiple assignment and deployment types rather than relying on traditional long-term, out-and-back assignments.

Policy reviews are most commonly focused on long-term assignments, permanent transfers, foreign local or international hires and short-term assignments. The 2025 survey showed slightly more organizations actively reviewing policies, at 60% compared with 53% in 2026, but the underlying message is consistent: organizations are reassessing whether existing mobility frameworks remain fit for purpose.

**Implications:** Policy strategy should move from one-size-fits-all assignment support towards segmented deployment pathways that match business need, talent intent, cost tolerance and risk profile.

# FLEXIBLE MOBILITY **OPTIONS**

## Flexible Options Provided for Long-Term Assignments



**Flexibility by Exception** Standard policy with flexibility granted case by case.

**Core / Flex** Policy offers Core and Flexible benefits.

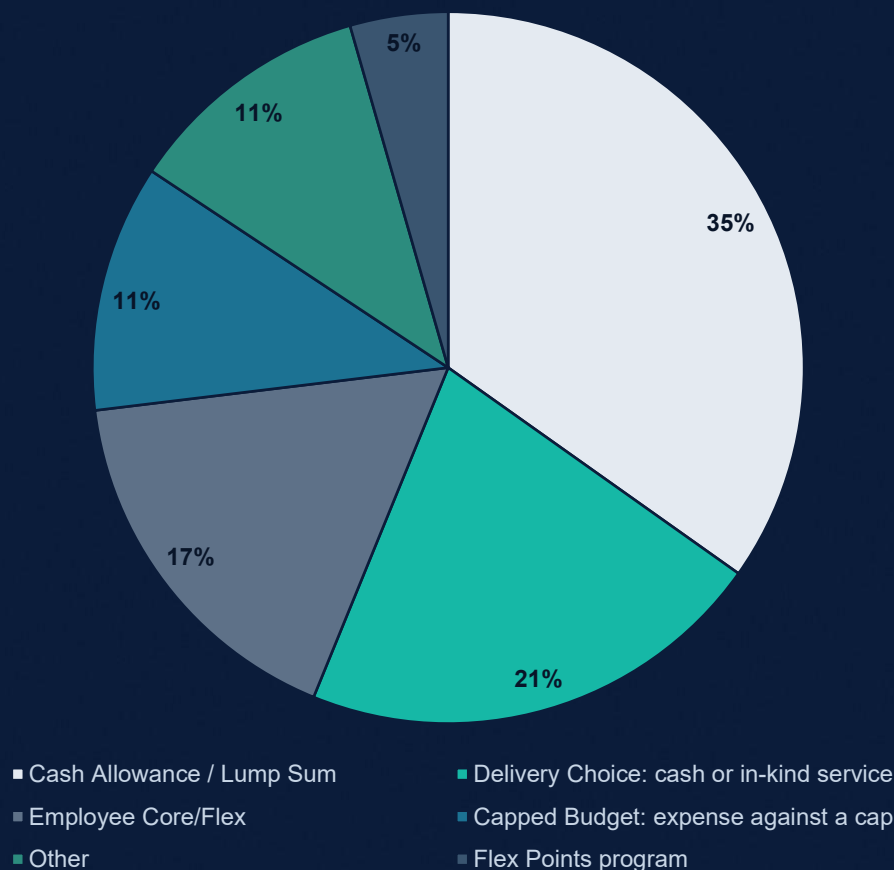
**Tiered Policy Design** Benefits structured by job level or other criteria within the same framework.

**Multiple Policies** Policies differentiated by purpose determining which policy applies, e.g. separate terms for standard and developmental policies.

**Single policy, little flexibility** All assignees transferred on the same policy, e.g. one long term policy for all.

# ALTERNATIVE DEPLOYMENT AND **HIRING MODELS**

## Options Offered to Assignees

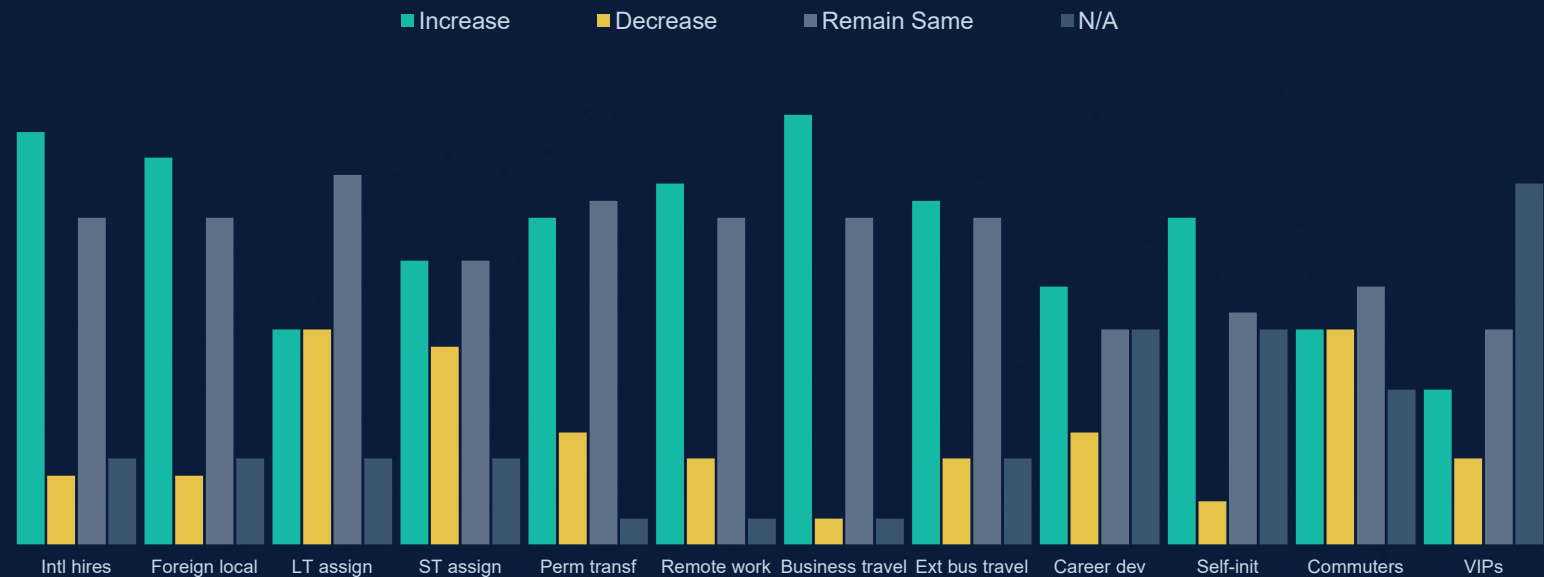


The responses indicate that flexible and alternative deployment options are becoming part of the broader mobility toolkit, although their adoption by global mobility teams remains selective. Organizations appear to be balancing employee demand for flexibility with the need to maintain control over cost, compliance and risk.

This selective adoption is important. It suggests that flexibility is becoming a strategic design principle rather than a universal entitlement. Organizations appear to be using flexible mobility options where they support a defined business or talent outcome, for example accessing scarce skills, supporting project delivery, enabling retention or providing a lower-cost alternative to a traditional assignment.

# ALTERNATIVE DEPLOYMENT AND **HIRING MODELS**

Change in the Level of Move Types



Alternative hiring and deployment models remain relatively cautious. While options such as Employer of Record arrangements, Global Employment Companies and other non-traditional structures can provide speed and market access, they also introduce additional governance, employment law, tax and reputational considerations.

Compared with 2025, alternative deployment models appear to remain more exploratory than mainstream. The direction of travel is clear: organizations want more routes to access talent and support business growth, but they are cautious about models that create additional employment, tax, immigration, payroll or reputational risk.

This reinforces the role of Global Mobility as a governance function as well as an enabler, helping the business assess when alternative models are appropriate and when a traditional employment or assignment should be used.

# ALTERNATIVE DEPLOYMENT AND **HIRING MODELS**

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The findings on alternative hiring models are particularly insightful because they move beyond the promise of flexibility to show the decisions mobility leaders must make in practice. Employer of Record and other non-traditional structures can unlock speed and access to talent, but this report rightly highlights that they work best when matched to a clear business need and supported by robust governance.

The report also offers a compelling view of evolving vendor partnerships. Its most innovative insight is that providers should be assessed not only on cost and service delivery, but also on their ability to bring technology, data, compliance expertise and a stronger employee experience to the mobility program.

## **Deb Convery**

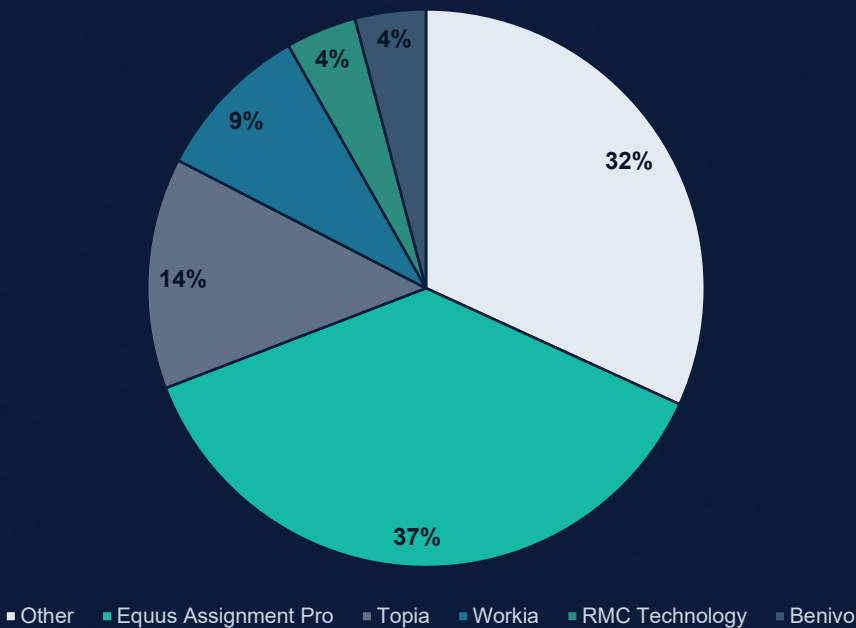
Head of Talent Mobility | Stripe



# TECHNOLOGY

Participants were split on the use of assignment management technology in their Global Mobility program, with 55% stating that they currently use technology. This represents a seven percentage point increase over the 2025 survey and suggests that technology adoption is continuing to move gradually upward. However, the continued reliance on Excel in many organizations indicates that digital maturity remains uneven.

## Assignment Management Platform Utilised



When asked whether they were considering purchasing assignment management technology, 40% of participants said no, 32% said yes and the remaining considered this not applicable. AI adoption remains at an early stage. Half of respondents stated that they are not currently using AI, while 35% are using it and a further 15% considered the question not applicable. Even so, the direction of travel is clear.



## How this compares with the wider market

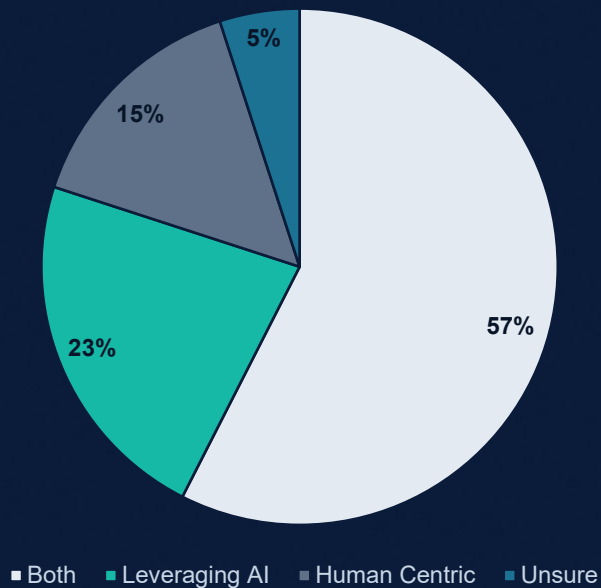
The wider market is slightly further along the curve: in the CBIQ benchmark 28% of leaders are not yet using AI in mobility operations, 26% are planning to, 23% are piloting and 23% are using AI in production. Survey participants are more cautious than the wider market, a gap worth watching over the next 12 months.

Base: approximately 830 Global Mobility leaders · CBIQ benchmark

# TECHNOLOGY

The survey results indicate that organizations are not yet looking to AI as a replacement for expert judgement. Instead, the likely near-term opportunity is to use AI to reduce administrative effort, improve consistency, surface risks earlier and give mobility professionals more time to focus on advisory work. This reinforces the broader theme of the report: technology will have the greatest impact where it supports, rather than replaces, human expertise.

## GM will be more Human Centric or more focused on Leveraging AI

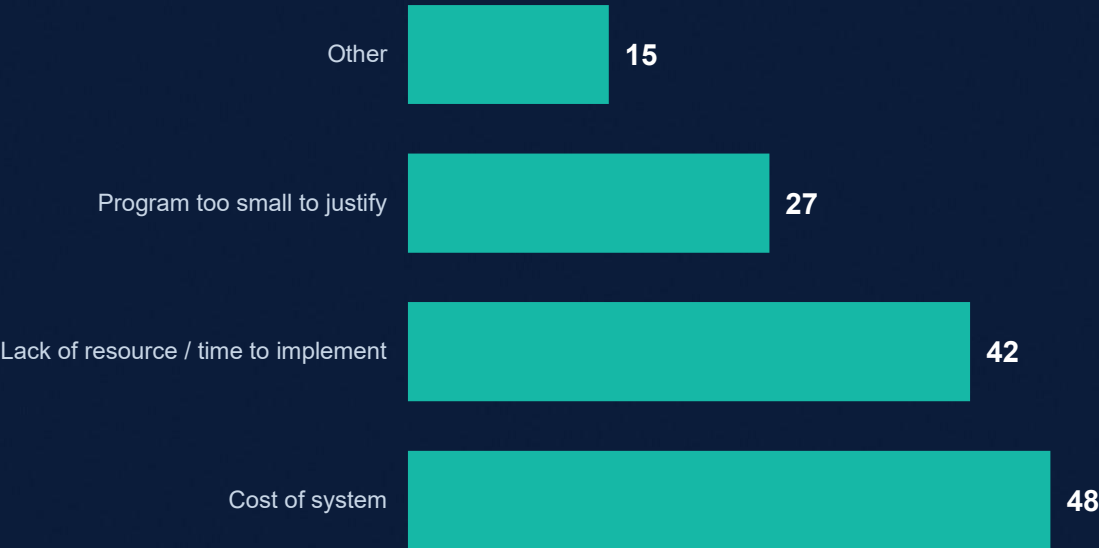


Compared with 2025, the 2026 technology data points to a market that is moving from awareness to more deliberate adoption. The opportunity for Global Mobility teams is not simply to digitise existing processes, but to use technology to create better visibility across the mobility ecosystem, improve case tracking, strengthen compliance controls and generate data that can support strategic conversations with the business.

The continued presence of manual tools also highlights why technology investment needs to be linked to a clear operating model and measurable benefits.

# TECHNOLOGY

## Barriers to using Technology in GM Program



The key message from the technology and AI responses is that digital maturity is becoming a differentiator for Global Mobility functions. Organizations that can combine reliable data, workflow automation and human expertise will be better positioned to provide strategic insight, manage risk and scale support without simply adding headcount.

However, technology investment will need to be accompanied by clear governance, data protection controls and careful change management to build confidence among both employees and stakeholders.

**Implications:** Technology strategy should be anchored in the outcomes Mobility needs to deliver: visibility, compliance control, employee experience, efficiency and insight. AI should be introduced through controlled use cases while preserving expert review for higher-risk decisions.

# TECHNOLOGY

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The GME 2026 Global Workforce Deployment Survey makes it clear that Global Mobility is entering a new phase of digital maturity, one where technology and human expertise are expected to work together, not in competition. The mobility community is being asked to manage more complexity, more compliance risk, and more stakeholder expectation without a corresponding rise in headcount.

One insight that stands out to me: only 55% of organizations currently use assignment management technology, and just 35% have adopted AI in any form. Yet when asked how they see the future, 57.5% want a model that combines both human judgement and AI-enabled support. The appetite is there. The infrastructure is not there yet.

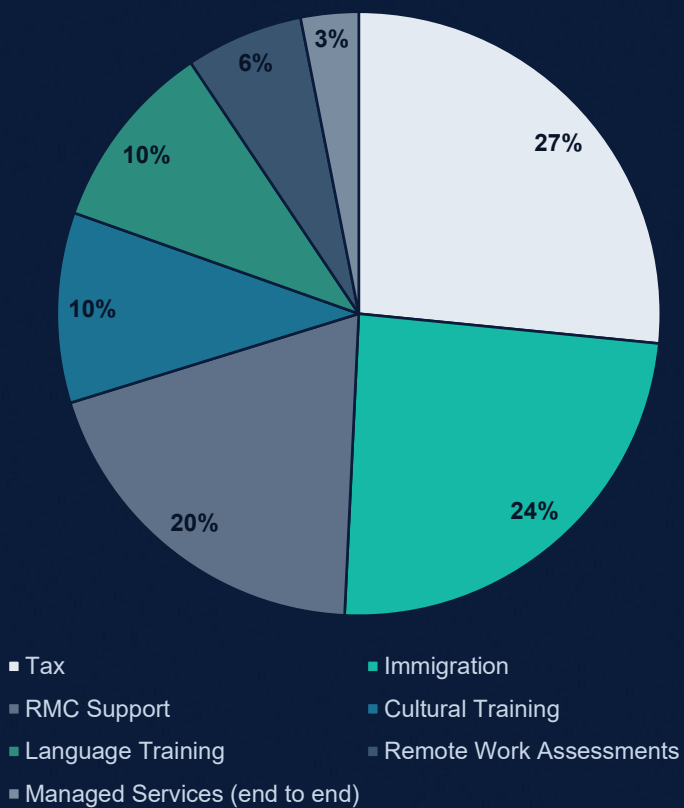
Look closely at the barriers cited: cost of system, lack of time, programs too small to justify. These are not technology problems. They are investment case problems, waiting for the right champion to step forward. The future of Global Mobility will belong to leaders who stop treating AI as a threat to expert judgement and start treating it as the tool that frees experts to advise, influence, and guide people through the most consequential moves of their careers.

**Sola Osinoiki**

GME Advisory Board

# VENDOR RELATIONSHIP

## Which Tasks Do You Outsource to Vendors

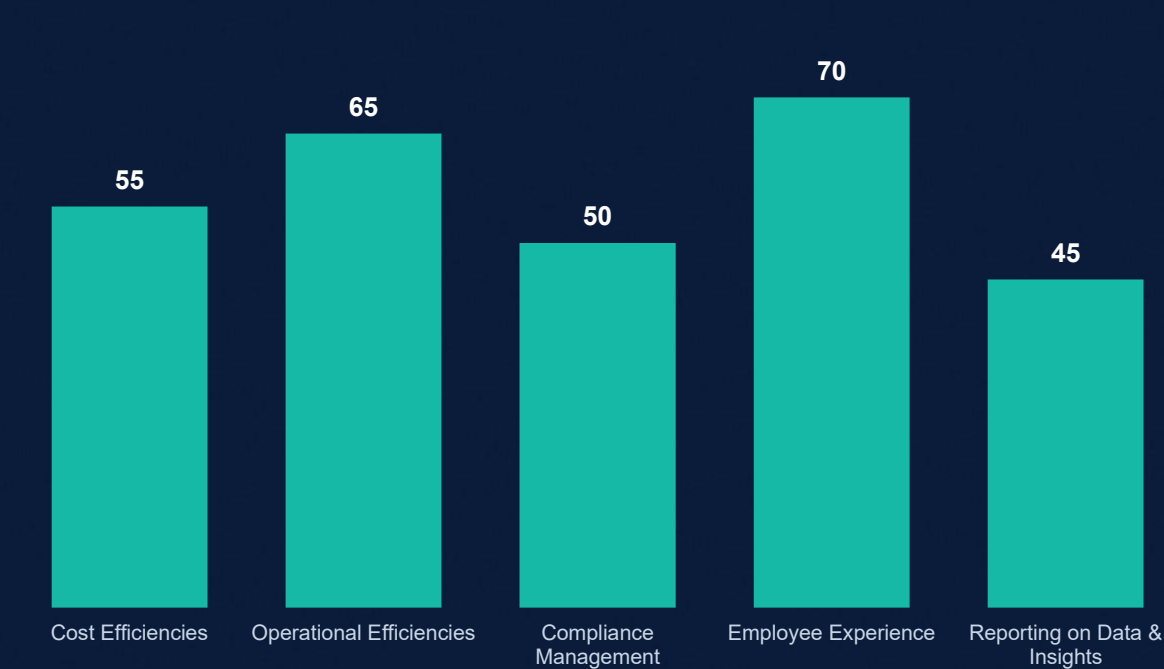


The responses to the questions on vendor relationships highlight the continued importance of external specialist support in Global Mobility delivery. Immigration, tax, destination services, temporary housing and relocation management remain areas where organizations frequently rely on external providers, reflecting both the technical complexity of these services and the need to manage risk across multiple jurisdictions.

The findings suggest that outsourcing is no longer simply a way to remove transactional work from internal teams. For many organizations, it is becoming part of the broader mobility operating model: internal teams retain ownership of policy, governance, stakeholder management and strategic decision-making, while external partners provide specialist capability, market knowledge and scalable delivery support.

# VENDOR RELATIONSHIP

## How Vendors Contribute to the Success of Program

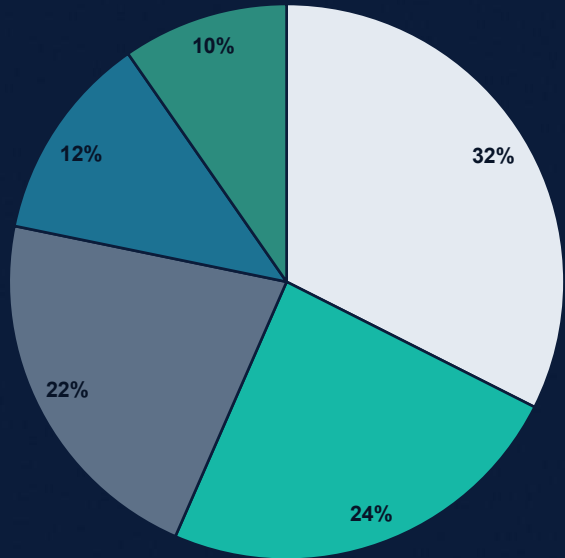


When asked whether they had recently been through an RFP, 52% of participants stated that they had, while 30% said they had not and 12.5% said they were considering conducting one. This level of RFP activity suggests that many organizations are reassessing whether their current vendor arrangements remain fit for purpose in a more complex and cost-conscious environment.

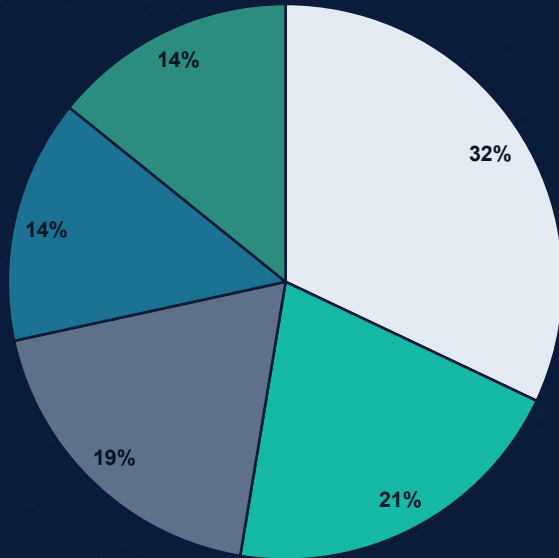
The drivers behind RFP activity are likely to be broader than price alone. Organizations are increasingly looking for partners that can support compliance management, provide better data, improve the employee experience and offer technology-enabled service delivery. In this context, vendor selection becomes a strategic decision.

# VENDOR RELATIONSHIP

Reasons for Conducting an RFP



Biggest Challenges in an RFP



The vendor selection data points to a market in which organizations are looking for more than transactional delivery. While cost remains important, decision-making is increasingly shaped by the need for stronger compliance support, better technology, clearer reporting and a more consistent employee experience. This reinforces the importance of treating vendor partnerships as strategic relationships.

The 2025 report also highlighted vendor partnerships as an important feature of future operating models. The 2026 findings suggest this has become even more practical and immediate.



## How this compares with the wider market

One buying-behaviour signal from the wider market: among Global Mobility leaders in the CBIQ benchmark who have invested in technology, three-quarters say the investment was ultimately approved at CHRO or HR-director level, decisions are made above the mobility function, which shapes how the business case needs to be told.

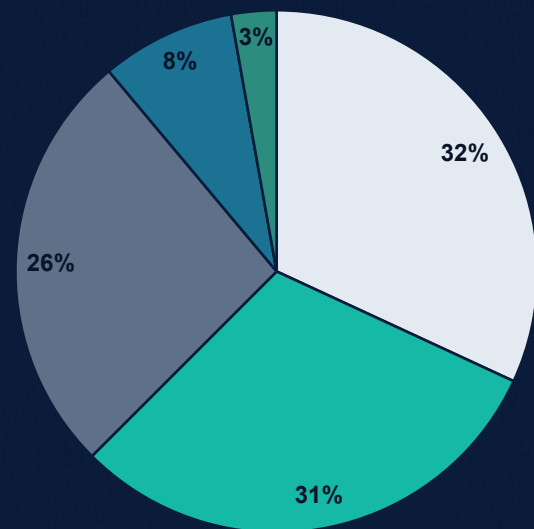
*Base: approximately 130 Global Mobility leaders · CBIQ benchmark*



# REMOTE WORK

Remote work, once seen primarily as a discretionary benefit, has become a mainstream consideration within global mobility strategy. It is now increasingly viewed as an attraction, retention and workforce-continuity tool. When asked about remote working, the majority of participants, over 67%, stated that they have a policy, while 32% do not.

## Circumstances Where Remote Work is Permitted



- Employees requesting to work from an international location while on personal travel
- Employees temporarily returning to home country to reconnect with family
- Only under exceptional circumstances
- Mutual benefit remote working
- Other

In response to the question on whether organizations require employees to have a legal right to work remotely in the relevant location, the vast majority, 85%, stated that they do, while 15% said they do not. This highlights the extent to which remote work is being managed through a compliance and risk lens, rather than as an unrestricted flexible benefit.

The vast majority of organizations, 85%, set a maximum time limit for remote working, with 30 days being the preferred policy position for 52% of participants. Only 7.5% allow 60 days, although a further 15% permit up to 90 days. This indicates that organizations are trying to provide flexibility while limiting the potential build-up of tax, immigration, payroll, social security and employment law risk.

# REMOTE WORK

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My key reflection from this data is that the conversation around remote work has matured significantly over the past few years. Organizations are no longer debating whether remote work should be supported; instead, the focus has shifted to how it can be leveraged as a strategic workforce deployment tool that enables access to talent, improves retention, enhances workforce resilience and supports business continuity.

At the same time, the findings demonstrate that organizations are becoming more sophisticated in their approach to managing remote work. Rather than providing unrestricted flexibility, employers are introducing clear governance frameworks, formal approval processes, risk assessments and defined eligibility criteria.

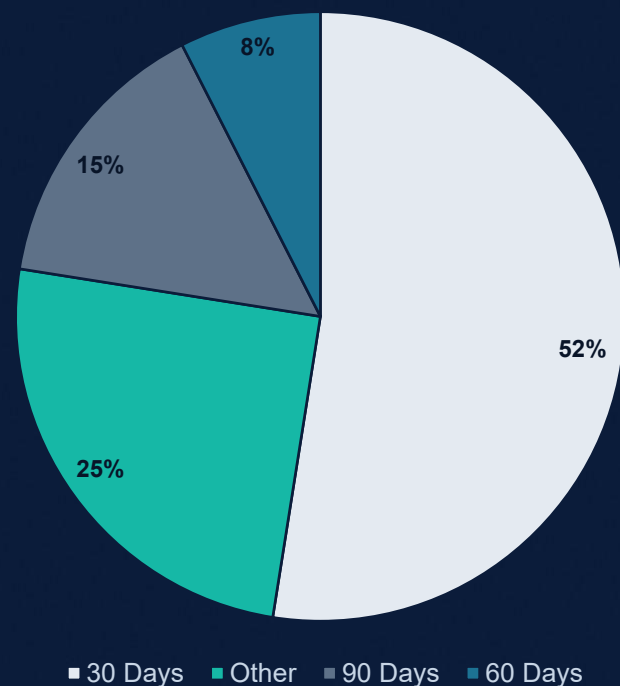
Perhaps the most significant insight is that successful remote work programs are no longer being measured by the degree of flexibility they offer, but by how effectively they balance employee choice with business needs and risk management. As global workforces become increasingly distributed, the challenge will not be enabling flexibility, but creating scalable governance models that allow flexibility to be delivered safely, consistently and sustainably.

**Nicelle Galeano**

Global Mobility Manager | CSIRO

# REMOTE WORK

## Maximum Remote Work Allowed



In terms of policy provisions, common features include clear limits on the frequency and number of days employees can work remotely, compliance and risk assessments before approval, and a strong preference for remote locations where the company already has a legal presence. This cautious approach reflects the complex legal and tax challenges remote work can bring.

Overall, remote work has become a standard Global Mobility consideration and signals a shift from traditional assignment-only thinking towards more flexible, employee-driven workforce models. Compared with 2025, remote work appears to have moved further into the core Global Mobility governance agenda; the emphasis is less on whether remote work should be supported and more on how it should be controlled.

**Implications:** Remote work strategy should clarify where flexibility supports attraction, retention, resilience or access to skills, and where it creates unacceptable risk. Operationally, organizations need standardised request processes, pre-approval risk assessments, day tracking, location governance and clear accountability.

# FINAL THOUGHTS

The 2026 Global Workforce Deployment Survey shows that Global Mobility is continuing to evolve from a primarily transactional and compliance-led discipline into a strategic workforce deployment capability. The findings point to a function that is increasingly expected to support business growth, enable talent development, strengthen organizational agility and help employers respond to a more complex global operating environment.

Across the survey, several themes are clear. Organizations are seeking greater alignment between Global Mobility, Talent, Rewards and broader workforce strategy. They are reviewing policies to create more flexible and segmented deployment options, while still maintaining strong governance around cost, compliance and risk. Technology and AI are recognized as important future enablers, but adoption remains cautious and uneven, with most organizations favouring a model that combines human expertise with technology-enabled support.

## Strategic

Global Mobility is increasingly embedded in enterprise workforce planning, not treated as a downstream service.

## Segmented

Policy frameworks are becoming modular and business-led, matching the move type to objective, cost and risk.

## Technology-enabled

AI and assignment technology support rather than replace expert judgement, freeing teams for advisory work.



# Thank you for reading.

The 2026 findings are a snapshot. Here is how to go further with both the data and the community behind it.



## See where you stand

Explore the full CBIQ live benchmark and segment it by industry, region and company size to compare your program against the market.

[Explore at cbiq.ai](https://cbiq.ai) >



## Join the community

Global Mobility Executive brings senior leaders together through the Leaders Exchange, GME Live and the Leadership Circle. Join to get the next report first.

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